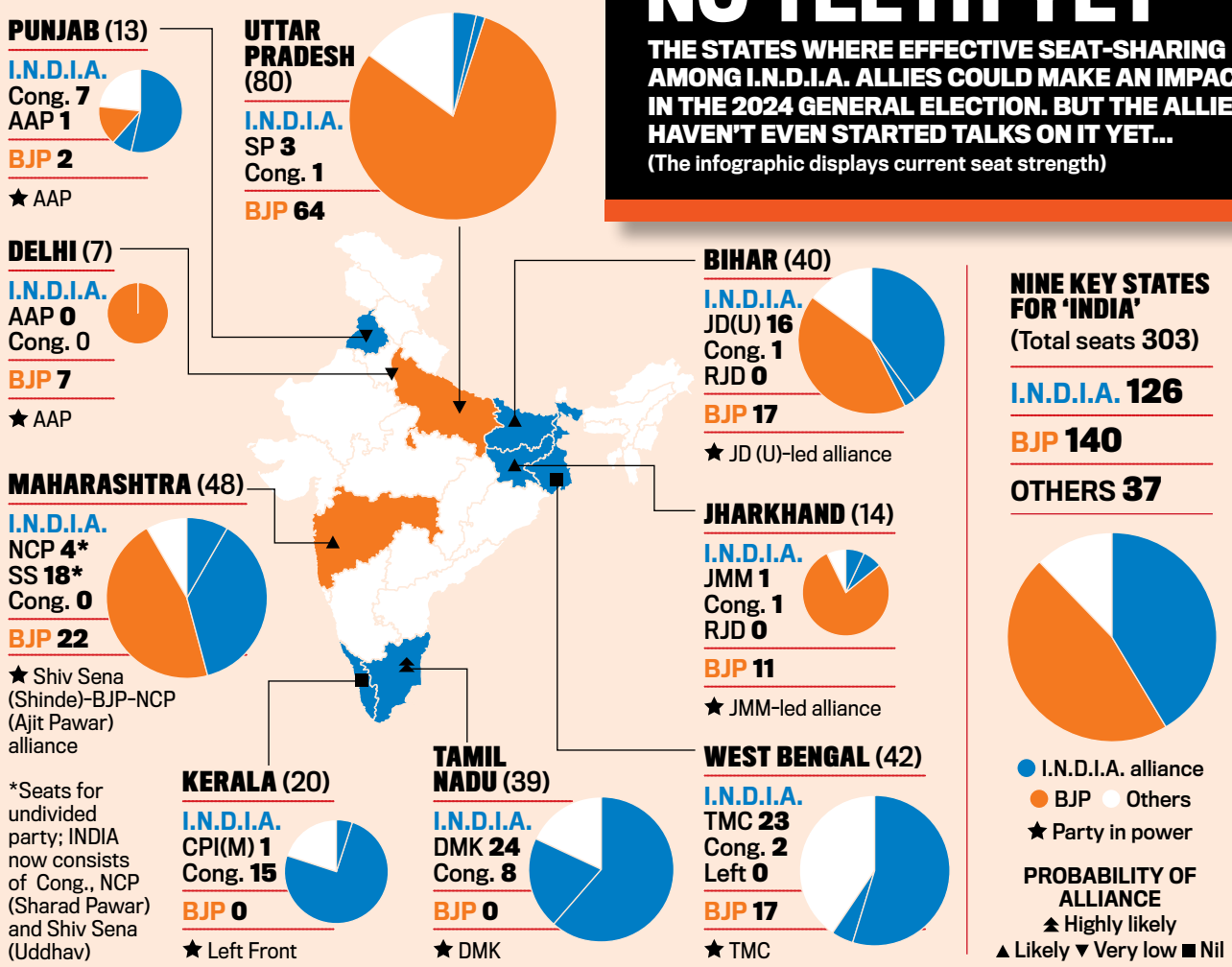
NO TEETH YET

THE STATES WHERE EFFECTIVE SEAT-SHARING AMONG I.N.D.I.A. ALLIES COULD MAKE AN IMPACT IN THE 2024 GENERAL ELECTION. BUT THE ALLIES HAVEN'T EVEN STARTED TALKS ON IT YET...

(The infographic displays current seat strength)



Congress got busy with the assembly polls. The first joint rally of the alliance, which was to be held in Bhopal, too was called off as the Congress developed cold feet following the controversy over DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin's intemperate remarks on sanatana dharma. The hibernation finally ended on December 6 when the 14-member committee met for the first time at Kharge's home but failed to achieve much.

The Congress-imposed hiatus has expectedly caused discontent among the allies. In November, Nitish, who had first pushed the idea of a grand alliance against the BJP, blamed the Congress for "no progress" in the preparatory activities for the 2024 Lok Sabha election. The Congress, on the other hand, buoyant after two victories in Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka, was expecting a good show in the assembly polls in November, especially as it had won the three heartland states in 2018. It believed that victories in the latter would give the party more elbow room in negotiations with the regional forces of the INDIA bloc.

Now, the poll outcome has made the situation tougher for the national party. From the beginning, the allies have been insisting that the Congress should focus more on states where it is in a direct contest with the BJP and leave the others to the regional party that dominates the particular state. There are nine states where the INDIA bloc partners can team up, either to make a dent in the BJP's tally or prevent it from making a Lok Sabha debut—Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Maharashtra, Punjab and Delhi. These states account for 303 Lok Sabha seats. The INDIA bloc currently occupies 126 of them while the BJP has 140. The saffron party has no seat in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, and effective seat-sharing can arrest the BJP's sweep in the rest, particularly in big battlegrounds such as UP, Maharashtra, West Bengal and Bihar.

ALL POSTURING, NO PLAY

But that doesn't seem to be happening. The seat-sharing arrangement in UP, which has 80 LS seats, has hit a roadblock. The Congress queered the pitch by declining the request of the Samajwadi Party (SP) for six seats in the MP election. SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, who accused the Congress of betrayal, has now turned confrontational. Apart from turning down Kharge's invite for the December 6 meeting, he has made it clear that, in UP, the SP will dictate terms. "The Samajwadis' fight in UP is bigger and the SP has to make some big decisions. The [seat-sharing] talks will start from where they began. Wherever a party is strong, the others should support